

**Atlanta protests call for end to Flock Safety surveillance**
(02:08)[Local News](#)**Atlanta protest targets Flock Safety as debate over surveillance, ICE fears, and public safety intensifies**By [Zachary Bynum](#), Rashad Williams

Updated on: April 17, 2026 / 5:38 PM EDT / CBS Atlanta

Add CBS News on Google

On a stretch of Howell Mill Road, where tech offices meet a rapidly changing Atlanta skyline, a protest planned for Friday is shaping up to be about far more than a single company.

Organizers are calling it "Flock and ICE Out of ATL," a demonstration aimed at [Flock Safety](#)-but the tensions surrounding it reach into deeper questions about surveillance, policing, and who gets to define public safety in 2026.

At the center of it all: a growing unease over how [data](#), [technology](#), and [power](#) intersect in everyday life.



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE



A Flock Safety surveillance camera is installed.

Flock Safety/ flocksafety.com

A protest rooted in a bigger moment

Friday afternoon's rally outside Flock Safety's Atlanta headquarters, comes amid mounting scrutiny of license plate reader technology nationwide. Organizers say the protest is part of a broader movement challenging surveillance infrastructure and its potential consequences.

According to event organizers, more than 30 cities across the country have recently reconsidered or canceled contracts tied to similar technology, reflecting what they describe as a shift in public awareness.

"This is about rejecting surveillance as a model for public safety," said Reem Suleiman, a campaign director with Fight for the Future, one of the groups behind the protest.

Watch CBS News

View CBS News In



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE



Protest organizer discusses community concerns over surveillance.

CBS News Atlanta

Sarah Philips, one of the group's organizers, said Flock Safety is not wanted in the city, and she said fears continue to rise for people's safety and privacy, particularly those in immigrant and marginalized communities.

"We do not want Flock in our communities," Philips said. "We don't want Flock in Atlanta. We don't want Flock in Georgia. We don't want Flock in the United States,



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

"On the way here [to the protest], I think I may have passed 20 Flock cameras," Arnold said. "So, my car was tracked 20 times just getting here, and the question is, do we really want to be living in this type of community where surveillance is now the answer to public safety?"

What Flock Safety says

Flock Safety, which provides automated license plate reader (ALPR) systems to law enforcement agencies across the country, says it welcomes the protest as part of the democratic process—but strongly disputes key claims driving it.

"There is misinformation out there that Flock works with ICE... and it's simply not true," company spokesperson Holly Beilin told CBS News Atlanta.

Beilin said the company does not have contracts with federal immigration agencies, including ICE or Customs and Border Protection, and instead primarily serves local police departments.



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

The Flock Safety spokesperson addresses questions about public safety technology.

CBS News Atlanta

She also emphasized built-in safeguards, including:

- Data retention limits (typically 30 days)
- Audit logs tracking every search in the system
- Tools to flag unusual usage patterns by law enforcement

The company argues that its technology can reduce bias in policing by focusing on specific vehicle data—rather than subjective suspicion—and has helped solve crimes, locate missing persons, and intercept suspects.

Where the disagreement begins

But critics say the issue isn't just about formal contracts—it's about how data moves once it exists.

Organizers and advocates argue that even if companies don't directly partner with federal agencies, information can still be accessed indirectly through local law enforcement networks or informal sharing practices.



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

They also raise broader concerns:

- The scale of surveillance across cities, businesses, and neighborhoods
- The potential for misuse or unauthorized access
- The impact on immigrant communities and marginalized groups

Some critics go further, questioning whether surveillance technology actually prevents crime — or simply documents it after the fact.

Atlanta as a flashpoint

Atlanta's role in the debate is not incidental.

The city has become a focal point for conversations about policing, surveillance, and civil liberties—from the "Cop City" protests to ongoing debates in suburbs like Dunwoody and Brookhaven over public safety technology.

Advocates say that context makes this moment feel urgent.

"Atlanta is one of the most heavily surveilled cities in the country," Suleiman said, arguing that residents should question how that infrastructure is used and who it ultimately serves.



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

The line between safety and surveillance

At its core, the debate reflects a broader national tension: how to balance safety with privacy in an era where data is constantly collected, stored, and analyzed.

Flock Safety says that balance is achievable and necessary.

"We certainly believe that you can have both," Beilin said, pointing to limits on data storage and oversight mechanisms built into the system.

Critics remain unconvinced.

"If public safety comes at the expense of certain groups... that cannot be public safety," Suleiman said.

What happens next

For now, both sides appear dug in — but Friday's protest could serve as a turning point in a debate that has largely played out in city council meetings, policy documents, and advocacy campaigns.

Organizers say success isn't necessarily measured in immediate policy change, but in visibility.



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

For Flock Safety, the moment is an opportunity to push back on what it sees as widespread misconceptions.

And for Atlanta residents, the question may be less about one protest – and more about what kind of city they want to live in:

One where technology quietly watches in the name of safety, or one where that very watching becomes the issue.

More from CBS News

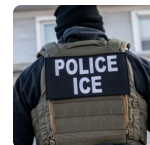
CBS PHILADELPHIA

Neighbors welcome man home to Downingtown, after months in ICE detention



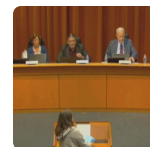
CBS TEXAS

Man deported 3 times accused of ramming ICE vehicles during Lewisville traffic stop



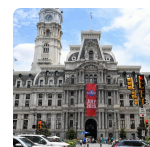
CBS DETROIT

Woman removed from Taylor city meeting after tense moment over ICE



CBS PHILADELPHIA

Philly City Council's "ICE Out" bills become law, limiting cooperation with ICE



In: [Immigration](#) [U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement](#)

[Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency](#) [Atlanta](#) [Data Privacy](#)

View CBS News In



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

Iran War Coverage

NFL Draft Grades

NBA Playoff Bracket

Follow Us On

YouTube

Facebook

Instagram

X

CBS News Atlanta

Meet the Team

Program Guide

Contact Us

Advertise With Us

Terms & Conditions

Sitemap

Regulation

Public File for WUPA-TV

Public Inspection File Help

FCC Applications

Watch CBS News

View CBS News In



CBS News App

OPEN

CONTINUE

[Minors' Privacy Policy](#)

Company

[About Paramount](#)

[Advertise With Paramount](#)

[Join Our Talent Community](#)

[Help](#)

[Feedback](#)

[Contact the Ombudsman](#)

©2026 CBS Broadcasting Inc. All Rights Reserved.